



GALLUP®

The Trust in Media Initiative

Powered by USC Annenberg,
TIME, McKinsey and Gallup

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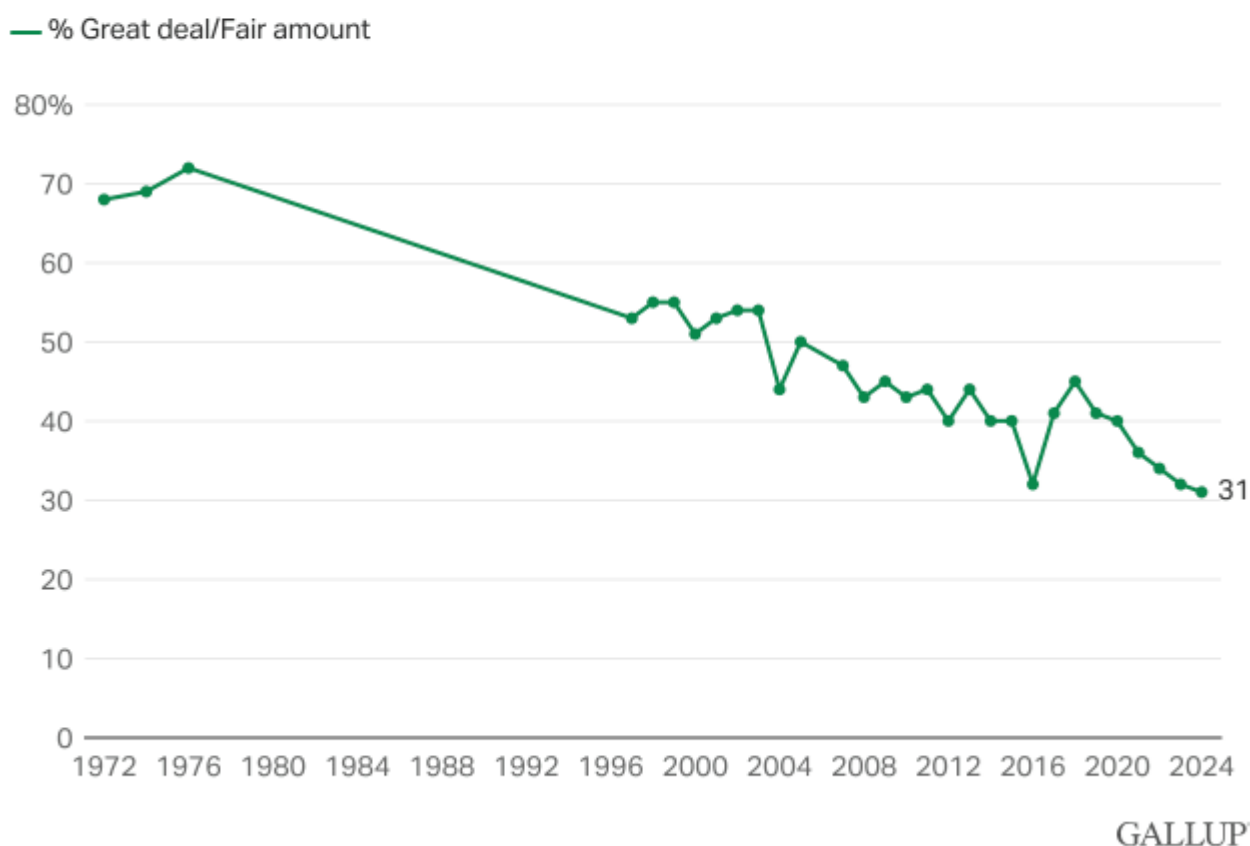
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Introduction

Trust in the media is in freefall. In 1976, nearly three-quarters of Americans said they trusted mass media to report the news fully, accurately and fairly. Today, that figure has plummeted to just 31%, with a growing share of the public — now more than one in three — expressing no trust in the media at all. These are not minor fluctuations. They reflect a foundational fracture in the American public sphere, one with far-reaching implications for journalism, for our democracy, and for the possibility of shared truth in a fragmented information ecosystem.

State of Americans' Trust in Mass Media, 1972-2024

In general, how much trust and confidence do you have in the mass media -- such as newspapers, TV and radio -- when it comes to reporting the news fully, accurately and fairly -- a great deal, a fair amount, not very much or none at all?



The causes of this collapse in trust are complex and evolving. The digital transformation of the news landscape has radically changed how information is produced, distributed and consumed. The lines between journalism, commentary and entertainment have blurred. Social media, algorithms and AI-generated content have become dominant entry points to information, while misinformation and disinformation thrive in a low-trust environment. In the absence of agreed-upon standards for truth and accuracy, public confidence in nearly every type of media institution — such as newspapers, television and online platforms — has eroded. And this erosion is not merely a reflection of partisan division; recent data show that even groups historically more trusting of the press, such as Democrats and college-educated adults, are now registering steep declines in confidence.

This decline in media trust does not exist in isolation. It mirrors a broader institutional crisis in American life, where confidence in government, higher education, the judiciary and public health authorities has steadily deteriorated. As Gallup has documented, Americans are losing faith not just in one institution, but in the very architecture of institutional authority. When people no longer believe they can trust the sources of information, they become less capable of participating in civic life, holding leaders accountable, or making informed decisions as voters and citizens.

The result is not just polarization, it is disorientation.

The collapse of a shared informational foundation leaves the public vulnerable to manipulation, breeds cynicism and weakens the democratic norms that depend on a reasonably informed electorate.

What we lack is not speculation about the problem; we see it every day. What we lack is the kind of rigorous research that can precisely track these dynamics over time, uncover their root causes, and provide actionable insights that media organizations, educators, technologists and policymakers can use to rebuild trust. Fragmented polling and episodic studies have offered valuable snapshots, but they do not provide the resolution or consistency needed to navigate this moment. We need a system of record — one that can capture the speed of change, illuminate the experiences of diverse audiences, and surface the factors that either erode or reinforce public confidence in the news.

This is the ambition of the USC Annenberg-TIME-McKinsey-Gallup Trust in Media Initiative. Building on Gallup's 50-year trend line and methodological leadership, this initiative will create the definitive, ongoing measure of how Americans perceive, interact with and place their trust in media. This study will offer an unparalleled view into one of the most urgent and consequential challenges of our time — not just to document the problem, but to understand how it can be solved.

The Trust in Media Initiative

The Trust in Media Initiative is designed to serve as the nation's most credible and continuous measure of public trust in the media. It is not a one-time report or a fleeting poll — it is a long-term public data asset, purpose-built to track the state of trust, identify its drivers and offer practical insight to those working to rebuild it.

This study is built to meet the moment with consistency and depth. Gallup will survey a nationally representative sample of 3,500 U.S. adults using its probability-based panel, twice per year. This frequency and sample size will enable ongoing measurement of public trust across media types, audience segments and political identities. It will allow leaders to understand how trust varies not only over time, but across age groups, racial and ethnic communities, political affiliations and levels of media literacy. It will surface the specific experiences and perceptions that shape whether people trust the news they consume.

This initiative will be designed to both track long-term shifts in attitudes through a stable core module and adapt to the moment by incorporating rotating questions on current events and emerging issues. In doing so, it ensures staying power while remaining timely and relevant, capturing enduring trends, surfacing new dynamics and equipping institutions with reliable, actionable data to guide their work.

This initiative reflects a rare convergence of capability and reach. Gallup provides the methodological foundation and long-standing authority in measuring trust in institutions. USC Annenberg brings deep academic expertise in journalism, communication and civic discourse, ensuring the findings are not only rigorous but actionable within the field. TIME adds the visibility, amplification and reach necessary to elevate this research into the public domain, where it can inform national narratives and institutional behavior. McKinsey brings deep expertise in advising global media, technology and information services companies, helping industry leaders translate insights into actionable strategies that strengthen business models, rebuild consumer confidence, and address the economic implications of trust and misinformation. Their participation ensures that findings are not only published but also embedded in industry practice, policy frameworks and board-level decision-making.

Together, these partners are building more than a research study — they are building a mirror and a feedback loop for a critical American institution. In a climate of accelerating distrust, fragmented attention and informational overload, this study offers a stable, empirically grounded signal. It will inform how journalism is practiced, how media literacy is taught, how public policy is shaped, how businesses adapt their strategies in low-trust environments and, ultimately, how trust can be earned.

The Power of Partnership

The Trust in Media Initiative is made possible by a unique alignment of four institutions, each bringing complementary strengths that together create a platform far greater than the sum of its parts. Individually, each partner offers a distinct capability. Collectively, they provide the infrastructure to measure, amplify and operationalize the future of trust in media.

USC Annenberg — Informing and Shaping the Initiative

USC Annenberg brings academic leadership in journalism, communication and civic discourse. By anchoring the work in academic expertise, USC Annenberg ensures that the measures of trust are not only methodologically sound but also responsive to the realities of newsrooms, civic life and democratic institutions.

Gallup — Conducting the Research and Building the Data Asset

Gallup contributes its methodological authority, nationally representative probability-based panel and more than five decades of institutional trust data. Gallup leads the design, fielding and analysis of the survey, producing a continuous stream of quarterly reporting and ongoing measurement. The result is the creation of a massive new public data asset, the nation's official system of record on trust in media, which will serve scholars, journalists, policymakers and industry leaders for years to come.

TIME — Amplifying the Findings and Shaping Public Narrative

TIME ensures that the findings do not remain confined to the academy or policy circles. Through its immense editorial reach, TIME elevates the results into the national conversation. TIME makes the findings part of the cultural narrative, sparking debate and influencing how the media ecosystem is covered by other outlets.

McKinsey — Operationalizing the Findings for Action

McKinsey extends the impact of the initiative by translating insights into practical strategies for industry, government and philanthropy. Drawing on its deep expertise in media, technology and information services, McKinsey ensures that findings can be embedded in boardroom decisions, newsroom strategies and public-sector responses. By aligning Gallup's research with McKinsey's global advisory capabilities, the initiative becomes not only a measurement platform but also a catalyst for solutions.

Together — A System of Record and a Platform for Change

Together, these partners create a closed loop of research, amplification and action. USC Annenberg ensures rigor, Gallup provides the data, TIME amplifies the story, and McKinsey delivers application and strategy. The result is a platform that not only tracks the erosion and rebuilding of trust in media but also equips the institutions that shape American democracy with the tools to respond.

Project Approach

Research Agenda and Foundation Establishment

The first phase of the study will set the foundation by defining the research agenda and identifying the core indicators that will be tracked over time. Gallup will lead a working session with USC Annenberg, TIME, McKinsey and invited experts to prioritize the most critical constructs for measuring media trust and engagement. This session will focus on pinpointing the areas where public understanding is weakest and new insights are most needed.

To inform this work, Gallup will contribute its extensive archive of validated survey items and long-term trends on media trust, spanning nearly 50 years. This unique resource will ground the project in proven measures while allowing the team to innovate around emerging challenges.

Survey Design

Gallup's team of public opinion researchers, survey methodologists and communication experts will work closely with USC Annenberg, McKinsey and TIME to design a robust survey instrument that captures how Americans experience, evaluate and engage with today's media and information ecosystem. The survey will build on the insights gathered in the Research Agenda and Foundation Alignment phase. Topic areas may include, but are not limited to, trust in news and information, perceptions of accuracy and fairness, transparency of sourcing, independence from political influence, civic knowledge, and patterns of news consumption and avoidance.

Drawing on input from the core project team including designees of USC, TIME, and McKinsey, Gallup will develop a robust survey instrument that combines continuity and adaptability. Core indicators will remain constant across all years to allow for long-term tracking, while flexible modules will address timely developments in the media ecosystem. This approach ensures the study's integrity as a longitudinal instrument while capturing the volatility and speed of change in how Americans access, interpret and act on information.

The questionnaire will be developed through a collaborative, iterative process that includes working sessions with the project team members from USC Annenberg, McKinsey, TIME, and other project stakeholders. This process will ensure that the instrument aligns with the project's conceptual framework, academic standards and broader communication goals. Gallup brings decades of experience translating complex concepts of trust, civic life and media engagement into survey items that are accessible, clear and actionable for both scholarly and public audiences.

Once a draft instrument is developed, Gallup will conduct a round of cognitive interviews with respondents reflecting the demographics, media habits and lived experiences of the populations being studied. This process ensures that questions are easy to interpret, elicit the intended information and resonate across diverse groups. During each cognitive interview, participants will be asked to:

1. Explain how they interpret specific survey instructions, questions and response options;
2. Describe how they would approach answering each question and what considerations inform their responses; and
3. Provide suggestions to improve clarity or reword questions they find confusing, overly technical or difficult to answer.

Through this process, Gallup will evaluate whether survey items are comprehensible, contextually appropriate and cognitively feasible. The team will assess whether each question measures the intended construct and whether respondents are equipped with the knowledge or experience to answer accurately. Gallup will also identify opportunities to minimize response burden and reduce survey fatigue, ensuring a high-quality, respondent-friendly instrument that supports valid and reliable measurement over time.

Sampling and Data Collection

Gallup will conduct semiannual surveys with a nationally representative sample of 3,500 U.S. adults using the Gallup Panel, the largest and most methodologically rigorous probability-based research panel in the United States. The Panel is built using address-based sampling (ABS) and includes adults aged 18 and older across all 50 states and the District of Columbia. Unlike opt-in or convenience panels, members of the Gallup Panel are recruited through scientifically randomized outreach methods and are not self-selected.

This structure ensures broad coverage across demographic, geographic, political and behavioral groups, including those often underrepresented in media research, such as lower-income households, rural residents and individuals who report disengagement from traditional news sources.

Data will be collected using web-based instruments optimized for mobile and desktop access. Each wave of the study will be fielded over a three- to four-week period, allowing for timely analysis and the flexibility to incorporate emerging topics as necessary. Gallup will apply appropriate post-stratification weights to align the sample with national population benchmarks from the U.S. Census Bureau's Current Population Survey (CPS) and other federal sources.

The sampling plan will also allow for oversampling of specific groups when needed to ensure analytic power in areas of strategic interest, such as younger Americans, Black and Hispanic communities, politically independent respondents and heavy users of particular news platforms. These decisions will be made in collaboration with USC Annenberg, McKinsey and Time during the annual agenda review process.

All data collection procedures will adhere to Gallup's internal protocols for respondent confidentiality, IRB compliance and data security.

Data Analysis and Reporting

Each wave of data will undergo a rigorous vetting process that includes data cleaning, validation and weighting to align with national population benchmarks from the U.S. Census Bureau and other federal sources. Weights will be applied to correct for sampling design, nonresponse and demographic imbalances to ensure that all estimates accurately reflect the U.S. adult population.

Data analysis will focus on both trend tracking and subgroup differentiation. Gallup will report changes in indicators over time and highlight statistically meaningful differences across demographic groups, political affiliations, media consumption patterns and other relevant variables. The study design allows for consistent measurement of long-term trends while also creating space for timely, issue-specific analysis based on developments in the media ecosystem. Analytic techniques will include descriptive statistics, cross-tabulations, time-series analysis and multivariate modeling, depending on the complexity of each research question.

Gallup will produce four summary reports (which may be hosted on Gallup.com as articles) each year. To maximize reach and visibility, Gallup's in-house strategic communications team will support media amplification at key milestones. This includes targeted media pitching to national outlets, partner-aligned press outreach, and coordinated messaging across USC Annenberg, TIME and McKinsey channels.

Once per year, Gallup will develop a flagship public report that offers a deeper synthesis of findings and longitudinal shifts, packaged for broad dissemination through Gallup.com, USC Annenberg's academic and journalistic channels, McKinsey's thought leadership communications and TIME's media platforms. These reports will include visualizations, explanatory narratives and, where appropriate, commentary or analysis from subject matter experts at USC Annenberg or contributing journalists from TIME.

To maximize visibility and engagement, Gallup will host the flagship report and related content on a dedicated, co-branded USC Annenberg-TIME-McKinsey-Gallup Research Hub on Gallup.com. This dynamic web destination will serve as the central home for annual releases, summary reports, blogs and media features — amplified by TIME, grounded by Annenberg and activated by McKinsey.



Ongoing Survey Evolution and Sustained Engagement

After each survey wave, Gallup will review and refine the survey instrument to ensure it reflects emerging issues in the media ecosystem while preserving the integrity of key longitudinal measures. This approach enables consistent tracking of shifts in trust, credibility, news engagement and civic knowledge over time, while remaining responsive to new cultural, technological and political dynamics that shape how Americans interact with information.

The survey will maintain a core set of trended questions to allow for meaningful year-over-year analysis. A smaller portion of the instrument will remain modular, enabling the inclusion of new items aligned to current priorities, such as perceptions of journalistic independence, use of AI-generated content, generational differences in news habits or the role of platforms in shaping access to information.

Gallup will field the survey semiannually to a representative sample of 3,500 U.S. adults per wave via web, using its probability-based Panel. Upon completion of data collection, Gallup will clean, weight and analyze the data. Following the completion of both semiannual data collection waves, Gallup will develop and deliver a flagship report co-developed with USC Annenberg and TIME. The report, approximately 20 pages in length, will be accompanied by public-facing social media content designed to extend reach and amplify impact across both scholarly and media audiences.

Investment

Gallup proposes the Trust in Media Initiative as a three-year program, with a total cost of **\$1,441,740**.

The program is structured around a stable, repeatable research cadence. Detailed investment and timeline details are below.

Phase I: Foundation and Research Agenda (February 2026 – April 2026)

Gallup will establish the project roadmap and develop the survey instrument with input from the USC, TIME, and McKinsey project team members.

Investment: \$153,800

Phase IIa: Baseline Survey and Initial Findings (April-June 2026)

Gallup will field, analyze the first survey (n=3,500). Gallup will develop the first annual Gallup.com article to publicize the findings.

Investment: \$163,900

Phase IIb: Public Launch and National Kickoff (July 2026)

Gallup will support the public launch of the research at a USC-hosted event.

Investment: \$0 (base budget)

Phase III: Ongoing Tracking and Reporting (July 2026 - January 2027)

Gallup will conduct the second semiannual survey. Gallup will develop 3 additional Gallup.com articles, to be released quarterly and an annual report up to twenty pages in length.

Investment: \$164,550

Phase V: Continued Measurement Cycle (February 2027-January 2029)

Gallup will conduct two surveys per year with 3,500 respondents per wave, produce four Gallup.com articles, and deliver one 20-page annual report.

Investment: \$479,745 per year

Appendix A: Methodology Details

Sampling Plan

Gallup will use its proprietary, probability-based Gallup Panel. The Gallup Panel is composed of approximately 100,000 U.S. adults aged 18 years and older. Established in 2004, Gallup recruits panelists using random-digit-dialing (RDD) telephone sampling procedures, including landline and cellphones, and address-based sampling (ABS) procedures. Unlike most “opt-in” panels, Gallup scientifically selects panel members. Gallup carefully weights sampled individuals to represent the U.S. population or other target populations using established national statistics published by the U.S. Census Bureau and other federal statistics agencies.

The panel supports cross-sectional, time-series and longitudinal survey designs. Panel members can be surveyed via web, mail, telephone, SMS or mixed modes of survey administration. Currently, approximately 87,000 panel members complete surveys via the web. Gallup recruits new members on an ongoing basis to replace members who have left the panel.

There is no time commitment for membership in the Gallup Panel. Rather, individuals are encouraged to remain members as long as they are willing and interested. They agree to participate in an average of three surveys per month. Surveys are typically self-administered (either by mail or web, depending on the internet accessibility of the respondent), but can be administered by an interviewer via phone if appropriate.

Gallup maintains strong retention rates which support longitudinal data collection for projects that require tracking the same respondents over time. Gallup partners with many academic institutions that are interested in surveying respondents multiple times per year, or year over year. In a typical longitudinal survey, Gallup finds approximately 80% of respondents will complete the second request to participate, which allows Gallup’s clients to track change among the same respondents over time.

The Gallup Panel performs very well in terms of eliminating professional respondents who tend to volunteer for opt-in panels. This “pay for play” incentive model makes opt-in panels vulnerable to professional survey respondents who attempt to maximize their income by dissembling on screeners to qualify for and complete a high volume of surveys. To address the issue of professional survey respondents, Gallup has several safeguards in place:

- Careful use of screeners and incentives. Gallup uses careful screening and sampling procedures for all surveys that use an incentive. Screening questions are short, and it is difficult for respondents to detect the “correct” answer. For many surveys, enough is known about the respondent that screening is not even required. This helps minimize the chance that respondents might lie on screeners.
- The Gallup Panel uses random digit dialing (RDD) of landlines and cellphones and address-based sampling to recruit its members. In other words, individuals cannot self-select to become Gallup Panel members in any way. However, the opt-in panels are formed entirely through the process of self-selection.
- The Gallup Panel has a controlled survey assignment environment. Members are not bombarded with surveys all the time. Because of this, our panel members tend to provide higher-quality data. Gallup Panel members consent to participate in about three surveys per month with some exceptions.
- Reactive approaches to screen professional respondents. As part of ongoing R&D exercises to check data quality, Gallup Panel surveys embed quality checks to identify and eliminate respondents who are either not paying adequate attention or spend an inordinate amount of their time taking surveys. In addition to this, other possibilities beyond quality checks are also included on an ad-hoc basis, such as excluding cases where survey length is above the cut-off limit and rotating simple verification questions (e.g., what year were you born?).

Cognitive Interviews

Once the survey draft is finalized, Gallup will begin the cognitive interview process to test the survey instrument. Gallup will conduct up to 10 cognitive interviews across potential survey respondent generations to ensure all pathways are fully tested. The purpose of the cognitive interviewing process is to ensure items are clear, easy to interpret and focused on eliciting the desired information from respondents. In the cognitive interview process, Gallup will ask participants to:

1. Discuss their interpretation of survey instructions, questions and response choices;
2. Discuss the process in which they would go about answering the questions; and
3. Provide any recommendations to clarify question wording for unclear or difficult-to-answer items.

The cognitive interview process will allow Gallup to evaluate respondent comprehension, item relevance to the sampled population, the extent to which it is feasible for respondents to answer a survey question, and the steps required to select a response. It will also allow Gallup to identify methods available to reduce total respondent burden and minimize survey fatigue. Gallup will provide any recommended changes that result from this process to the project team.

Data Collection

The survey will be administered to a nationally representative sample of 3,500 U.S. adults, twice per year, yielding 7,000 completes annually. The instrument will be designed to take 10 minutes in total, with approximately five minutes dedicated to a stable core module for longitudinal tracking and five minutes reserved for rotating content that addresses emerging issues in the media ecosystem. This balance ensures consistency in key measures while allowing flexibility to capture timely developments.

Once the survey instrument is finalized, Gallup's team of web programmers will implement it using industry best practices in online survey design, including full mobile optimization for respondents on smartphones and tablets. The programmed instrument will undergo thorough testing, and USC Annenberg and TIME will receive a secure test link and access codes for review and approval before each semiannual launch. Online respondents will receive a unique, secure access code from Gallup to complete the survey, supported by reminder notifications as needed. Respondents will also receive a small post-paid incentive, a proven method for improving participation rates and ensuring sample representativeness. The survey platform will support complex logic (skip patterns, rotations, open-ended collection) and will generate real-time monitoring of completes and response rates. This allows Gallup to confirm data quality within minutes of launch and to provide regular updates — weekly or even daily — on progress.

Data Analysis

Upon completion of data collection, Gallup will clean, vet and weight the data to correct for nonresponse and ensure results are fully representative of the U.S. adult population. Final weights will be calibrated to national demographic benchmarks derived from authoritative sources such as the U.S. Census Bureau's Current Population Survey (CPS).

Each year, Gallup will develop an analysis plan in collaboration with USC Annenberg and TIME, ensuring the work reflects the initiative's evolving priorities and aligns with both scholarly and public-facing communication goals. This plan will be refined to deliver insights that are statistically valid, relevant and actionable for academic research, journalism and civic dialogue.

The analysis will examine national trends, subgroup differences and longitudinal shifts across core dimensions of the project, including media trust, credibility, perceptions of accuracy and fairness, transparency, independence and engagement behaviors. As the data set grows over time, Gallup will integrate year-over-year comparisons to track cultural shifts in how Americans consume, evaluate and rely on media.

In addition to core tracking, future analyses may include segmentation modeling, multivariate regression and thematic deep dives into priority areas such as generational differences in media use, trust in emerging technologies (e.g., AI in news production), polarization and source selection, or the civic consequences of

media avoidance. These advanced analyses will inform targeted storytelling, editorial strategy, policy discussions and broader public engagement.

Appendix B: Three-Year Implementation Plan: Month-by-Month Breakdown

Year One: 2026

- **February 2026:** Gallup conducts a project alignment session to inform the development of the survey instrument.
- **March 2026:** Gallup develops first draft of the core survey instrument.
- **April 2026:** Gallup conducts cognitive interviews to test clarity and comprehension of survey items. Survey programming, testing, and quality assurance are completed.
- **May 2026:** The first semiannual survey is fielded to the nationally representative sample.
- **June 2026:** Data from the first wave are cleaned, weighted, and analyzed. Gallup publishes the first Gallup.com article presenting initial findings.
- **July 2026:** Gallup supports the public launch and dissemination of the findings at a USC event.
- **August 2026:** Instrument review and refinement and preparation for fall fielding.
- **September 2026:** Gallup publishes a second Gallup.com article drawing on findings from the first wave.
- **October 2026:** The second semiannual survey is fielded.
- **November 2026:** Data from the second wave are cleaned, weighted, and analyzed. Gallup publishes a third Gallup.com article presenting findings from the fall data collection.
- **December 2026:** Gallup synthesizes findings from both Year One data collection waves and prepares the Year One annual flagship report.

Year Two: 2027

- **January 2027:** Gallup releases the Year One annual flagship report and publishes a fourth Gallup.com article synthesizing findings from the prior year.
- **February–April 2027:** Gallup conducts structured review and revision of the survey instrument, incorporating lessons from Year One and preparing for Year Two fielding.
- **May 2027:** The third semiannual survey is fielded.
- **June 2027:** Data are cleaned, weighted, and analyzed. Gallup publishes a Gallup.com article based on the spring data collection.
- **July 2027:** Reporting and preparation for fall fielding continue.
- **August 2027:** Instrument review and final preparations for fall fielding.
- **September 2027:** Gallup publishes a second year two Gallup.com article drawing on findings from the spring wave.
- **October 2027:** The fourth semiannual survey is fielded.
- **November 2027:** Data are cleaned, weighted, and analyzed. Gallup publishes a Gallup.com article presenting findings from the fall wave.
- **December 2027:** Gallup synthesizes findings from both Year Two data collections and previous Year One findings, and prepares the Year Two annual flagship report.

Year Three: 2028

- **January 2028:** Gallup releases the Year Two annual report and publishes a fourth Gallup.com article synthesizing findings from the prior year.
- **February–April 2028:** Gallup conducts structured review and revision of the survey instrument, incorporating lessons from Year Two and preparing for Year Three fielding.
- **May 2028:** The fifth semiannual survey is fielded.
- **June 2028:** Data are cleaned, weighted, and analyzed. Gallup publishes a Gallup.com article based on the spring data collection.
- **July 2028:** Reporting and preparation for fall fielding continue.
- **August 2028:** Instrument review and final preparations for fall fielding.

- **September 2028:** Gallup publishes a second Year Three Gallup.com article drawing on findings from the spring wave.
- **October 2028:** The sixth semiannual survey is fielded.
- **November 2028:** Data are cleaned, weighted, and analyzed. Gallup publishes a Gallup.com article presenting findings from the fall wave.
- **December 2028:** Gallup synthesizes findings from both Year Three data collections, as well as key findings from Years One and Two, and prepares the Year Three annual report for January release.